

Thus, with a load of corporate drama, the group that eventually became Kering was formed. The trouble for Ford and De Sole was that Pinault now essentially wanted control. In 2004—with the Gucci Group valued at more than $10 billion—they were suddenly out. "It was a divorce, and let's just say the other party filed for divorce." His reaction? "It was grief and it took me years to get over that. I don't mean that I thought it was mine. I mean I gave as much of myself as I would anything. It was a part of me and I was a part of it."

I remember the fraught emotion at his last Gucci afterparty in Milan on February 25, 2004. He wore a black tuxedo with a white gardenia buttonhole—he'd perfected his old-time Tom Ford movie star look by then. There were lots of hardened press and international buyers in tears. His PRs let it be known he would leave on the stroke of midnight. I found the gardenia fallen among the glitter afterwards. It was nothing if not dramatically choreographed.

On his plans to revolutionise the beauty industry

A fashion world without Tom Ford seemed unimaginable—he'd been that huge for ten years. I'd always wondered if he felt OK for money afterwards. He blinks. "Oh yes. I left Gucci never having to work again in my life because I had an enormous amount of shares." Never having to work again! Isn't that the fantasy outcome everyone dreams of? "I intended to just start making movies, but I missed fashion. I wasn't finished. I was still 40." Off he went again. He formed Tom Ford, at first as a beauty brand in 2006, making a stunning comeback with his ultra-expensive, black-packaged, heavily sexually suggestive fragrances—a high-selling success in every department store. He has won multiple fragrance awards for them, he reminds me. "Creating fragrances is my second favourite thing. I'm wearing my last one right now—Vanilla Sex!"

He has now exited fashion completely, after the spectacular sale to Estée Lauder of the Tom Ford empire, which by then also had womenswear and menswear ("It was all fitted on me. I'm a size 48"). He's honest: there has been emotional fallout. "Even after I'd started my own company, it took me years to really get over that [Gucci Group]. It honestly took me until Alessandro [Michele] started at Gucci, then, well, Gucci all of a sudden felt ... I felt good about Gucci again!" He claims not to look at much of what's going on in fashion now. (I'm not sure I quite believe that.) But he is looking forward to seeing Haider Ackermann settling in at the brand he founded. "He needs to come in and take it to the next level. I don't know how to do that. I am of an era."



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